



Office of Public Affairs
U.S. Department of Justice



Woman Sentenced for Fraud Scheme Involving Claims for Unnecessary Respiratory Tests Submitted with COVID-19 Tests

Tuesday, January 28, 2025

For Immediate Release

Office of Public Affairs

A California woman was sentenced today to nine years in prison for her role in fraudulently submitting claims to governmental and private insurance programs during the COVID-19 pandemic for expensive respiratory pathogen panel (RPP) tests that were medically unnecessary and never ordered by health care providers.

According to court documents, Lourdes Navarro, 66, of Glendale, and Imran Shams owned and controlled Matias Clinical Laboratory, doing business as Health Care Providers Laboratory (HCPL). Navarro and Shams conspired to obtain nasal swab specimens that enabled HCPL to test for COVID-19, as well as to obtain testing orders from physicians and other medical professionals. The specimens were collected from, among others, residents and staff at nursing homes, assisted living facilities, rehabilitation facilities, and similar types of facilities, and from students and staff at primary and secondary schools, for the purported purpose of conducting screening tests to identify and isolate individuals infected with COVID-19. However, Navarro and Shams caused HCPL to perform RPP tests on most of the specimens, even though only COVID-19 testing had been ordered and there was no medical justification for conducting RPP tests on asymptomatic individuals who needed only COVID-19 screening tests. Through HCPL, Navarro and Shams billed approximately \$369 million for the RPP tests to Medicare, the Health Resources and Services Administration COVID-19 Uninsured Program, and a private health insurance company, and were reimbursed approximately \$46.7 million for fraudulent claims.

Navarro was also ordered to forfeit \$11,662,939 in funds that the government had previously seized from three bank accounts. The total amount seized and forfeited from Navarro and Shams is \$14,518,485. Navarro also was ordered to pay \$46,735,400 in restitution.

Navarro [pleaded guilty](#) on Oct. 5, 2023, to conspiracy to commit health care fraud and wire fraud. Shams pleaded guilty on Jan. 24, 2023, in the Central District of California to conspiracy to commit health care fraud and concealment of his exclusion from Medicare and was [sentenced](#) to 10 years in prison on Jan. 30, 2024. In addition, on May 29, 2024, Shams was sentenced to five years in prison in connection with his 2017 plea in the Eastern District of New York to conspiracy to commit money laundering, conspiracy to pay and receive kickbacks, and defrauding the United States by obstructing the lawful functions of the IRS, of which three years were ordered to run consecutive to the Central District of California sentence.

Supervisory Official Antoinette T. Bacon of the Justice Department’s Criminal Division, Assistant Director in Charge Akil Davis of the FBI Los Angeles Field Office, and Acting Special Agent in Charge Rochelle Wong of the Department of Health and Human Services Office of Inspector General (HHS-OIG) Los Angeles Regional Office made the announcement.

The FBI and HHS-OIG investigated the case.

Trial Attorneys Gary A. Winters and Raymond E. Beckering III of the Criminal Division’s Fraud Section prosecuted the case. Assistant U.S. Attorney Maxwell Coll for the Central District of California handled the financial penalties.

The Justice Department’s COVID-19 Fraud Enforcement Task Force marshals the resources of the department in partnership with agencies across government to enhance efforts to combat and prevent pandemic-related fraud. The task force bolsters efforts to investigate and prosecute the most culpable domestic and international criminal actors and assists agencies tasked with administering relief programs to prevent fraud by, among other methods, augmenting and incorporating existing coordination mechanisms, identifying resources and techniques to uncover fraudulent actors and their schemes, and sharing and harnessing information and insights gained from prior enforcement efforts. For more information on the department’s response to the pandemic, visit www.justice.gov/coronavirus.

Updated April 25, 2025

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